



Photographs by PAUL RAFTERY

PROJECTS THAT MATTER
Surat Diamond Bourse integrates innovative architecture and sustainability in commercial spaces (left and top right); Vira Residence, a duplex in Delhi (above); exteriors of Aangan (below right)

GLOBAL BECOMES LOCAL

Sonali and Manit were students at the prestigious Architectural Association (AA) in London in the early 1990s, they noticed a glaring void. The AA gallery frequently showcased boundary-pushing architects from Japan, Norway, Australia and Mexico. Yet, throughout their entire four-year tenure, only one Indian architect's work was ever displayed, the late Charles Correa. "Indian architecture was simply not part of the global discourse," recalls Sonali. "There was almost no dialogue where Indian architects were part of the mainstream conversation. That was the starting point of our conversation. We knew we had to go back, work in India and play our part in making Indian design a definitive part of the global mainstream."

SUCCESS CAME EARLY

They tasted early, explosive success by winning high-profile commissions like the Apollo Tyres corporate office and a project for PVR during the dawn of India's multiplex boom. Then came what Sonali calls, "baptism by fire". Instead of an avalanche of new clients, the phone stopped ringing. "Suddenly, there was dead silence. No work," she shares. Just as panic was setting in, the universe intervened in the form of an unannounced, unsolicited visitor—a client roughly their age. He walked into the studio and asked point-blank: "Have you ever been to a mall? Do you know how to make a mall?" To this day, Sonali doesn't know how he tracked them down on a quiet Sunday, but that single encounter broke the drought. Morphogenesis hasn't looked back since.